

The Lost World

- It's the first time that a Buddhist monastery has been found in Vadnagar, establishing it as an ancient Buddhist settlement
- The excavations also establish Vadnagar as one of the few towns in India which has remained continuously inhabited over the past 2,200 years
- The discovery bolsters Vadnagar's age-old claim to be listed as a world heritage site
- Discovery of artifacts, coins and pottery provides proof of ancient trade links with the Greeks and Romans

Gandharva style. More fascinating is the discovery of pieces of Roman pottery in the form of amphoras, as well as decorative pieces of classical Greek art. Dalip Kushwaha, an archaeologist who assisted Rawat, says, "The discovery of these artifacts clearly indicates that Vadnagar must have had a trade link with the Romans and possibly even the Greeks."

Excavations by the team at two other spots have also confirmed Vadnagar's historicity. The findings show successive phases of occupation and construction over the past 2,200 years. The artifacts also reflect the socio-economic condition of different periods. These include coins of different dynasties and are of copper, silver, lead and potin (an alloy),

The most famous Buddhist settlement in Gujarat is at the foot of the Girnar Hills on Junagadh's outskirts in the form of inscriptions, caves and



RAWAT AND HIS TEAM OF FOUR AT THE EXCAVATED SITE IN VADNAGAR

“In archaeological terms, we have discovered a gold mine since it proves what Hieun Tsang had said.”

Y.S. RAWAT, *Director of Archaeology, Gujarat*

a water system built by Emperor Ashoka who spread Buddhism after embracing it following the Battle of Kalinga. The rock edict of Ashoka near Junagadh has 14 inscriptions describing the Buddhist edifice on which his empire was shaped. There are other Buddhist caves in Sana near Una and at Prabhas Patan, both in Junagadh district. Then there are two Buddhist caves in Talaja near Bhavnagar and Khambalida near Rajkot. The one at Khambalida has two large sized sculpted stone figures of Bodhisattvas—Padmapani and Vajrapani.

But the pride of Gujarat is undoubtedly Devnimori. According to the two inscriptions on the casket, there is a copper box inside which contains the Buddha's ashes. The inscriptions also name two monks who brought the Buddha's relics to

Devnimori and built the stupa and the monastery around it in the 4th century A.D. Before a dam submerged Devnimori village, important remains of the monastery, including the casket, were removed. Modi now plans to build a majestic Buddhist temple around the relics of Devnimori to draw South-east Asian Buddhist tourists.

Vadnagar has a huge, exquisitely carved "Kirti Toran", a gateway believed to be part of a great temple complex built during the Solanki era (also known as the Gujarat's golden age) before it was destroyed by Muslim rulers of the Sultanate period. A similar gateway was recently resurrected by the Archaeological

Survey of India. The two victory towers located near the main lake now make a splendid picture. With the latest discovery, Vadnagar's golden age may have just returned. ■

